the decline of the Congress even in Muslim-significant seats is consistent across both UP and the Hindi heartland.

That the BJP gained from greater Hindu vote consolidation in its favour after 2014, while religious minorities stayed away from it, has long been evident in voter surveys. Shreyas Sardesai, for example, studied NES data in both 2014 and 2019 to show that, for two national elections in a row, the BJP under Narendra Modi and Amit Shah was able to overcome caste hierarchies among Hindus and systematically construct a Hindu category of voters versus others. Yet, the study did not find sufficient evidence to support claims that a large part of the Hindu support for the BJP-led alliance was on account of anti-minority sentiments.[10] Outside of UP, nationwide, the BJP won more than 50 per cent of the Lok Sabha seats in ninety 'minority-concentration' districts identified in 2008 by the previous UPA government. Of seventy-nine such constituencies, the BJP won forty-one, a gain of seven over 2014. Overall, the party also fielded a handful of Muslim candidates in 2019, though not one of them managed to win.[11]

The Yogi Factor: Why It Works in Muslim-significant Seats

This Hindu counter-mobilisation works much more strongly in Muslim-significant areas, where Muslims can be projected as the 'Other', than it does in areas where Hindus are a comfortable majority. As a senior official in Yogi Adityanath's office explained to me, 'The mathematics [ganit] is that where Hindus are in a majority, where almost everyone is a Hindu, there Yogiji's impact is not that much in relative terms.' However, 'wherever Muslims are strong, say 30 per cent, Hindus there vote together for him. The reason is that they know that the Muslims are in front and they know what problem they can face. They know what happens there and they realise it immediately.'[12]

BJP leaders point to western UP, with its large Muslim concentration of voters, as a case in point. This is a region where, historically, the BJP had not done well, dominated as it was by the BSP and the Rashtriya Lok Dal (RLD). Yet, in 2019, Yogi Adityanath launched the party's campaign from the region's famous